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From the editor-in-chief

The decade was just about picking up speed in its second year when the horrific 9/11 happened and the world changed. America went to war and Islamic terrorism became a global threat. Internal security went to the top of every country's agenda. But as the decade closed America had a new president who coined the phrase "The Audacity of Hope". It was a slogan that powered him into the White House but it is also a theme that has underlined our Spirit of India series of special issues which we launched in 2008. We have just witnessed extensive coverage of the anniversary of 26/11 but what stood out the most were the stories of courage and sacrifice and hope. That confirms what we in the news business know from experience: people respond with great positivity to any story about human endeavour and surviving odds.

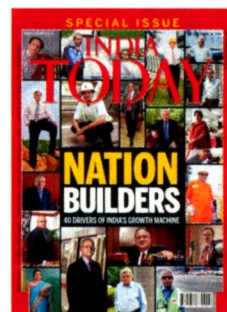
Today, India's growing global stature and influence stems from a series of narratives, about men and women and institutions and ideas which have forged a can-do spirit and made a difference in society. That is essentially the storyline of our special issues which started with Pioneers of Change, people who had transformed India through their work, institutions or ideas. Our next in the series asked outstanding achievers in various fields to write for us on the ideas that can change India and how those ideas could be implemented. The third issue focused on 50 wealth creators who have made it big in unusual ways. If Indian entrepreneurship was something to be proud of, so was our next segment on the youth which profiled young achievers in every field.

Every issue in the series was a revelation once we started to look at examples. That was certainly the case when we started looking for our next category, education, largely seen as a mess. We found many educational institutions, initiatives and individuals who had used education to make a vital difference. Similarly, in our last special issue on infrastructure, we found 40 examples in the private and public sectors that were outstanding milestones to India's progress.

This issue follows the same search for excellence but with a difference. Since we are entering a new decade, we have narrowed the time frame to the years 2000 to 2009. We believe the cataclysmic events that occurred make it the decade that truly changed the world, whether it was terrorism, the global economy, climate change, social networking, the telecom explosion, corporate takeovers and even the T-20 version that has revolutionised cricket. We picked 20 such themes and 20 eminent analysts from India and abroad to look at what the trends and events of the decade portended and what they signify for the future. We have eminent economist Jagdish Bhagwati assessing the decade; another world renowned economist Nouriel Roubini, who predicted the global recession, examines the impact and when it could end; Scotland Yard's terrorism expert Peter Clarke analyses its spread and how to counter it; we have former England cricket captain Nasser Hussain on the impact of T-20 on the game while Shiv Visvanathan does the same for social networking.

History is a series of cycles that offer key insights into the future. As we leave behind a decade that changed our world, our special issue represents a series of signposts to what lies ahead.

(Aron Purie)



OUR OCTOBER
2009 COVER